

Paper Chase: The Cratez (on sale at MagnaMixtapes.com)

When I got into listening to rap, which was around age 13, I wasn't sure exactly what it was I liked so much about it, other than the attitude behind it. After about a year of heavily exploring the various artists (this is back around 1998) it was becoming clear what appealed to me so much: the genius behind the attitude. Being a musician and lyric writer myself as long as I could remember, I began to dissect my favorite rhymes by my favorite rappers and quickly began to see patterns they all shared. These are the early patterns I began to design my rhymes after.

Music, just like math, has no two ways about it. For example, you couldn't rap a 4/4 verse over a 6/8 time signature – it just wouldn't work. If that makes no sense to you, don't worry, it doesn't have to. The point is, just like 1+1 will always equal 2, rhythms and beats will always only mesh accordingly as well. Even if the rappers I was idolizing and mimicking back then as a young teen didn't know it themselves, the reason their rhyme-styles were so effective was because they were all using different variations of the same winning pattern; or formula.

My favorite rappers back then are still my favorite rappers today (and for you die hard hip hop heads, I'm not claiming these to be the best, just the ones who happened to inspire me the most): Big L, Eminem, Nas, Biggy, and Krayzie Bone. Though they have no idea, those artists gave me the blueprint on to how to rap. By taking apart their rhymes and mapping them out by the syllable patterns within – which involved my own musical notation, breath, and underlining system – and taking strict note of where they threw in their metaphors, similes, and punchlines, I felt I had a firm grasp on a formula that I knew would work. Not long after developing this system I was morphing verses into my own styles that were based on what the greatest emcees before me had discovered.

For the next ten years I embarked on a journey with rap I'll never forget. And though these days my time is fully obligated to the production side of music with no time for being Paper Chase anymore, I still use the basic system of fundamentally taking apart the essence of things to master their inner workings to the best of my ability – it's worked so far I'd say.

So, what do those above rappers all have in common?

Musically and mathematically symmetrical rhyme patterns coupled with left field punchlines. After a few examples you'll see exactly what I mean.

BIG L

To me this guy is number one. Had he not been shot to death before the millennium passed, Big L would probably be the biggest name in rap today. Many artists near and around his city of Harlem had their start under L – Jay-Z and Ma\$e to name a few – and as he will tell you himself, “you can listen to my first album and tell where a lotta niggaz got they whole style from.” That's no exaggeration. Big L had the ability to rhyme multi-syllable phrases for days. Just listening to any of his lengthy freestyles online will show you his unbelievable talent, barbed delivery,

and perfectly structured flow.

So how did he do it? One thing I noticed while dissecting L's rhymes all those years ago was that you could put any of his rhymes over any other beat. That is to say, if he were to rap any of his rhymes side by side on the same beat without a pause between them, the audience would be none the wiser that he even switched from one verse to another – his flow is 100% mathematically tailored – and his punchlines are delivered in no more than 3 different syllabic patterns, making it no surprise they were effective every time.

Now to start we'll focus on the two syllable patterns L used most often. This is where he lands one rhyme word (or syllable) on the snare beat and the next word on the beat after the snare beat. This rule is just for the second and last rhyme in a 4 line (2 bar) sequence. For instance, when L say's:

"You better FLEE-HOPS
or get ya head flown THREE-BLOCKS
L keeps rappers hearts
pumpin like REE-BOKS."

The entire stanza (a paragraph in poetry terms) is designed to have THREE-BLOCKS and REE-BOKS landing on the snares; or to be more precise, on the 3 and 4 beats of the second and last half bars (4 beats each repeated 4 times within each stanza). Don't worry too much about the technical info if it confuses you, listen to Big L's rhymes while paying attention to his words in contrast to the snare beats and you'll realize what I'm saying pretty quickly. Here's another example of the same pattern:

"I put chumps to REST-FAST
when my Smith WEST-BLAST
So just dash or TRESS-PASS
and get ya CHEST-SMASHED."

There it is again. Same pattern; different song, and this pattern is everywhere in his rhymes. Of course there are variations off this pattern involving how he pronounces the words, but they remain under the same principal. For instance, instead of using only one syllable words in the designated rhyme spots, he uses two syllable words:

"So what you ACTIN'-FOR? You aint HALF AS-RAW
you need to PRACTICE-MORE
Somebody tell this nigga somethin'
'fore I CRACK HIS-JAW."

"Practice and crack his" are the two syllable words Big L threw into the spots he usually puts one syllable words, but as you see the principal stays the same – he just says the two syllable word quickly instead elongating a one syllable word. For any drummers, think of it as hitting two half notes on a beat. You could also put two, two-syllable words in the rhyme spots too and it works the same:

"You know I'm crazy quick

to SMACK A-GROUPY
I'm known to MACK A-HOOTCHY
Do I got STACKS OF-LUCCI, ABSO-LUTELY."

Since Big-L worked on this rhyme-scheme for years and years, he had it down to a science and you can see he threw in a lot more rhymes than just the second and fourth lines in a stanza. Actually, he peppered these multi-syllable rhymes throughout every 2 bars he wrote – that's why I think he's the best. He has the type of genius Shakespeare had, who could write entire works in iambic pentameter as fast as the common aristocrat could write a few sentences.

Another style L used more than often can be split into a few different variations as well, but we'll focus on the two most common. We'll call them Syllable Run 3 and Syllable Run 4. Big L liked to use both, but he mostly used Syllable Run 4. This is where the 2nd and 4th snares end with the rhyming word, and so do the three words preceding it. Here's an example:

"Fuck all the GLAM-MER AND GLITS, I
PLAN TO GET RICH
I'm from New York and never was a
FAN OF THE NICKS.

And I'm all about
exPAN-DIN MY CHIPS
You're mad cuz I was in a VAN WIT' YA BITCH, with both
HANDS ON HER TITS."

So you see: GLAMMER AND GLITS, PLAN TO GET RICH, FAN OF THE NICKS, exPANDIN MY CHIPS, VAN WITH YA BITCH, and HANDS ON HER TITS – they all rhyme front to back perfectly, at least audibly. Aside from being hilarious, this is a prime 8-line example of the four syllable rhyme scheme L used so much, and as you'll see, so does everyone else. As all of these basic shemes I'm mapping out for you can be morphed into something new, this scheme has another widely used variation using 3 syllables instead of 4. For this Three Syllable Run you just want to extend the first word in the run from 2 syllables to only one syllable, but still land the pattern the same way:

"It's over now nigga LEAVE THE GAME
I'm from the danger zone where emCEES GET SLAIN
where thugs'll never hesitate to SQUEESE THE FLAME
where niggas be takin' drugs just to EASE THE PAIN."

That's it. There are really only a couple other rhyme schemes Big L used that were variations of the ones we just went over. Hopefully that's enough to get the structure part making sense for you. Simply said, L didn't need to use any other patterns than these because these are the winning patterns. If you can master rhyming 4 syllables in 4 lines you'll be miles better than most rappers – especially today – it impresses the hell out of people.

What else made Big L's rhymes so dope? Well, this is a part not so easily picked up.

You're either clever or you're not. But there are a few ways to go about forming good punchlines in these patterns that could help you.

The secret to writing a good punchline is thinking of the punchline first, but leaving it until last. For example, when Big L said, "The crown is still mine, cuz I drop ill rhymes, a lotta rappers talk that murder shit and couldn't kill time." You can be almost certain that he thought of the last line first (rappers talk that murder shit and couldn't kill time); that's the clever part, that's the punchline, "Still mine" and "ill rhymes" are basically just filler, but you notice they came first in order. That's the secret!

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EMINEM

eminem

Unless you've been living on another planet for the past 17 years you know Eminem is one of the greatest, if not the greatest wordsmith to ever spit into a mic. Whether you agree with the content of his music or not, there is no getting around how genius Eminem is at forming rhymes. He basically took Big L's secrets to a new plateau, but again, he started with and still reverts back to the winning formula set out by Big L and the emcees of his ilk.

Take for example this rhyme, which fits the two syllable rhyme pattern by Big L above:

"You whacka then the muthafucka
you bit yo STYLE-FROM
You aint goin' sell 2 copies
if you press a double AL-BUM."

First syllable on the snare; musically the exactly the same. The next few rhymes in that track (Just Don't Give A Fuck) also follow the same pattern. We can also see Eminem use this same scheme, but placing two-syllable words in the rhyme spots too:

"These are the results of
a thousand eLECTRIC-VOLTS
a NECK WITH-BOLTS
nurse we're losin him CHECK THE-PULSE."

You can basically go through all the early D12, Outsidaz, and the Slim Shady LP to see that this, and variations of it, is the main rhyme scheme Eminem used to form his rhymes – and it still is, though he's taken it to all new heights now; he's a machine. But, just like Big-L, his most impressive rhymes came from 3 Syllable and 4 Syllable Runs. I'll leave it you to find the patterns and decode which is which.

"I'm sick enough to fuck a
Man In His Face
But I won't cuz you'd probably want to

Stand In His Place.”

“Told me she was goin’ back into
Usin again
I said wait first try this
hallucinagine.”

“An emcees worst dream, I
Make Them Tense
They fake, see me and shake like a
Chain Link Fence.”

These styles, just like L’s, are the most successful, clean, perfectly fitted blueprints for you to kill every rhyme, giving you more time to fill in the blanks with more razor sharp barbs every 4 bars. Just remember, think of the punchline first, and leave it til last.

Nas
nas

Nas, like Jay-Z in a way, has a flow all to himself that no one has been able to duplicate correctly. In my own opinion this is due to a level of sloppyness (for lack of a better word) of their writng technique. Jay-Z even to this day has sporadic bars that often don’t really rhyme with any pattern according to the beat he’s on.

Nas, on the other hand, does have patterns that he weaves in and out of which places his style along with the greats. These are the same patterns we just went over.

The two syllable rhyme pattern:

“Bullet holes left in the peep holes
I’m suited up with STREET-CLOTHES
Hand me a nine and I’ll
deFEAT-FOES.”

“Sometimes I sit
with a BUDDHA-SACK
mind’s in another world
thinkin’ how could we exist THROUGH-DA FACTS.”

The 4 and 3 syllable runs:

“Jungle unrolls it, puts his weed
BACK IN THE JAR
The blunt turns back
inTO A CIGAR.”

‘I never sleep, cuz sleepin is the
Cousin Of Death.”

You could honestly make a game out of going through all of the rappers the majority says are the best and find these patterns peppered throughout their most known songs. As I said, and hopefully have now explained, they are tested winners.

Study them and get to know them and your lyrics will, without a doubt, be leaps and bounds ahead of the rest.

by D. Thomas. Brought to you by <http://magnabeats.com>